

SEEDSCALE AGENCY

The AI *Playbook*

A practical, no-fluff guide to putting AI to work — and turning the skills you already have into income on your own terms.

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A note before you start.

There's a version of this guide that tries to scare you into action. This isn't that. AI is the leverage most of us have been waiting for — not because we needed permission to do more, but because we were already doing too much.

I spent fifteen years building digital systems at scale. I watched capable people undercharge, under-ask, and over-deliver while less qualified colleagues got promoted past them. The problem was almost never skill. It was leverage. AI changes the leverage.

This guide is about one thing: turning what you're already good at into income and options. Not learning forty tools. Not becoming a tech person. Finding the skill the market actually pays for, building the case for what you're worth, and making yourself harder to replace — using AI as the assistant you never had.

How to read this: don't. Not cover to cover, anyway. Start with the chapter that matches the itch you have right now — underpaid, stuck, or sitting on a business idea you haven't tested. Run the prompt in that chapter before you move on. One real action beats six chapters of nodding.

One ground rule: AI is leverage, not a replacement for your judgment. It's a sharp intern with no context until you give it some. The quality of what you get back is decided entirely by what you put in. Specific input beats generic every time. Feed it your real numbers, your real situation, your real words — and it gets useful fast.

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CHAPTER ONE

1. The Skills Audit

Most people I know can list what they're bad at in seconds and stall for a full minute on what they're good at. That's not modesty. It's that your most valuable skill is usually the one that feels easy to you — so easy you assume it's easy for everyone. It isn't.

The market doesn't pay for what's hard for you. It pays for what's hard for the person writing the check. Your job here is to find the gap between the two.

INVENTORY WHAT YOU ACTUALLY DO

Forget your resume for a minute. Resumes list titles. Titles hide skills. Instead, think about the last time a colleague said "how did you do that so fast?" or "can you just handle this?" Those moments are signal. Write down the messy, specific things people come to you for — not the polished job-description version.

SKILL EXCAVATOR

Paste a brain-dump of your work history, side projects, and the tasks people ask you for. Then run this:

"Here's a rough dump of my work and the things people come to me for: [paste]. Act as a sharp career strategist. Identify the 5 underlying skills I keep using across all of this — name the transferable skill, not the job. For each one, tell me where it's in demand right now and roughly what it's worth in the market. Flag any skill I'm clearly undervaluing."

SEPARATE THE COMMON FROM THE VALUABLE

Not every strength is a paycheck. A skill earns when three things overlap: you're good at it, it's in demand, and few people do it well. Run each skill from your list through that filter.

- **Good at it.** You can do it reliably, not just once.
- **In demand.** Someone is actively paying for this outcome.
- **Scarce.** The supply of people who do it well is thin.

The skill sitting in the middle of all three is your leverage. It's rarely the one on your business card.

CASE IN POINT

A client of mine ran ops at a logistics firm and thought their "skill" was scheduling. When we dug in, the real thing they did was untangle conflict between teams that wouldn't talk to each other — and translate chaos into a plan people would follow. That's not scheduling. That's a \$40k raise wearing a clerical disguise. They'd been pricing themselves as the calendar.

CHAPTER TWO

2. The Compensation Research

You can't ask for more if you don't know what "more" is. Most people walk into a raise conversation with a feeling and walk out with a no. The fix isn't confidence. It's data.

The goal of this chapter is a number you can defend out loud — and the argument that makes it land.

FIND THE REAL MARKET RATE

Pay ranges are wider than you think and quieter than they should be. AI is good at pulling the scattered signals — job postings, salary databases, freelance benchmarks — into one honest range for your role, level, and city.

MARKET RATE BUILDER *"I'm a [job title] with [X years] experience in [industry], based in [city/remote].*

My main skills are [list]. Based on current market data, give me a realistic salary range for my role — low, median, and high. Then tell me which 3 factors would push me toward the high end, and what someone at the top of this range can do that I might not be doing yet."

PICK YOUR NUMBER, THEN BACK IT

Don't ask for the median. The median is the floor for someone who's just adequate. You're aiming for the upper third — and you justify it with evidence, not vibes. Pull together the proof before you ever name a figure.

1. **The number.** A specific figure (or rate), not a range. Ranges invite the low end.
2. **The receipts.** Three to five concrete results you delivered, in outcomes, not effort.
3. **The market.** The data showing your number is normal, not greedy.

WRITE THE ARGUMENT

The conversation is won before you walk in, by deciding what you'll say when they push back. Have AI play the hard part.

RAISE REHEARSAL *"I'm asking for [number]. Here's my case: [paste your results + market data]. Act as my skeptical manager who has a tight budget. Push back the way a real boss would. After each objection, coach me on a calm, specific response that holds my number without apologizing."*

CASE IN POINT

A freelance designer I worked with was charging \$65/hour because that's what they charged three years ago. Twenty minutes of market research showed comparable designers at \$110–140. They raised their rate to \$120 on the next proposal, braced for pushback, and got a yes with no negotiation. The client had assumed they were cheap because they'd priced themselves cheap.

3. Career Leverage

Being good at your job is table stakes. It's also invisible. The people who get protected in a layoff and pulled into the big projects aren't always the most skilled — they're the most clearly valuable. There's a difference, and it's fixable.

Leverage means making it costly to lose you. Whether you're employed or freelance, the move is the same: be visibly tied to outcomes people care about.

MAKE YOUR WORK LEGIBLE

If your manager can't explain what you do in one sentence, you're at risk. The same is true for clients. Most people do valuable work and describe it in mush. AI is excellent at turning a vague contribution into a sharp, quantified line someone will remember.

IMPACT TRANSLATOR

"Here's something I did at work recently: [describe the messy reality]. Rewrite this as 3 versions of a one-line impact statement — each one quantified or tied to a business outcome (time saved, revenue, risk avoided, decisions enabled). Make it sound true and specific, not inflated. Then suggest one way I could make this visible to the people who decide my pay."

BECOME THE PERSON THEY ASK

Indispensable isn't about hoarding knowledge. It's about owning a problem nobody else wants to own — and being the obvious answer when it comes up. Pick one.

- **Own a recurring pain.** The thing that breaks every quarter that everyone dreads. Become the person who handles it.
- **Connect two silos.** Be the translator between teams that don't speak the same language. That role is rare and remembered.
- **Build the thing once.** Turn a repeated headache into a system or template. Now it has your name on it.

BE FINDABLE, NOT LOUD

Visibility isn't bragging. It's making sure the right people know what you're capable of before they need it. A short, specific update to your boss or a sharpened LinkedIn line does more than a year of quiet excellence.

CASE IN POINT

Someone on a marketing team kept fixing the broken handoff between their group and sales. Invisible work — until they spent ten minutes with AI turning it into a one-pager: "the handoff problem, what I changed, what it saved." They sent it to their director. Six weeks later, when a lead role opened, they were the obvious pick. Same work. Different visibility.

4. Testing a Business Idea

The most expensive thing you can do with a business idea is believe in it. Belief makes you build. Building costs months. And most ideas that feel obvious in the shower turn out to be solutions to a problem nobody will pay to solve.

This chapter is about finding that out in a week, for free, before you quit anything.

PRESSURE-TEST THE DEMAND FIRST

Don't ask friends if your idea is good — they'll lie to be kind. Ask whether the problem is real and painful enough that someone already pays to make it go away. AI is a useful sparring partner for poking holes before reality does.

IDEA STRESS TEST *"My business idea is: [describe it in 2-3 sentences]. The person I'd sell to is [who].*

Act as a blunt, experienced investor who's seen this fail before. Ask me the 5 hardest questions about whether real demand exists. Then tell me the single riskiest assumption I'm making — the one that, if wrong, sinks the whole thing."

FIND THE SMALLEST REAL TEST

You don't need a website, a logo, or an LLC. You need one signal that a stranger will pay. The smallest test is the one that produces a yes or no in days, not months.

1. **The conversation.** Talk to five people who have the problem. Don't pitch — listen for how they describe it and what they've tried.
2. **The offer.** Describe what you'd sell and ask if they'd buy. A pre-order, a deposit, a "yes, send me the link" is real. A compliment is not.
3. **The deliver-once.** Sell it to one person manually before you build anything repeatable.

READ THE SIGNAL HONESTLY

The test only works if you're willing to hear no. "That's interesting" is a no. "How much?" is a maybe. Money changing hands is a yes. Have AI help you script the conversation so you're testing demand, not fishing for praise.

VALIDATION SCRIPT *"I want to test whether people will pay for [idea]. Write me 5 questions to ask a*

potential customer that uncover whether they have this problem and have ever paid to solve it — without leading them or pitching. Then tell me which answers count as a real buying signal versus polite encouragement."

CASE IN POINT

Someone I advised was about to spend three months building a meal-planning app. Instead, they offered ten people a manual weekly plan over text for \$15. Four said yes and paid. Two asked for it weekly. That told them more than any business plan — the demand was real, but small and price-sensitive. They adjusted the model before writing a line of code.

CHAPTER FIVE

5. The AI Learning Path

You don't need to learn AI. You need to learn the two or three AI tools that move your specific goal forward. The rest is noise designed to make you feel behind.

Most "learn AI" content is a tool dump — fifty apps, no direction. That's how people end up with forty browser tabs and zero new income. Here's the focused version.

START FROM YOUR GOAL, NOT THE TOOLS

The right tools depend entirely on what you're trying to do. Someone negotiating a raise needs different skills than someone validating a business. Let your goal pick the curriculum.

PERSONAL LEARNING PATH *"My goal for the next 90 days is [raise / new clients / test a business idea / specific skill]. I have about [X hours] a week to learn. I'm a beginner with AI tools. Give me a focused learning path: the 3 AI skills that matter most for THIS goal, in order, with a one-line reason for each. Skip anything that doesn't directly serve this goal. No tool dumps."*

LEARN ONE SKILL THAT COMPOUNDS

If you learn nothing else, learn to prompt well. It's the skill underneath every other AI use, and it's the difference between generic slop and something you'd actually send. Good prompting is just clear thinking written down.

- **Give it a role.** "Act as a skeptical investor" beats "help me with my idea."
- **Give it your real context.** Specifics in, specifics out. Paste the actual situation.
- **Ask it to push back.** The most useful answers come from telling it to disagree with you.

PRACTICE ON A REAL PROBLEM

Don't learn AI in the abstract. Point it at the exact thing you're working on this week — the raise email, the idea test, the impact statement. Learning sticks when it solves something real in front of you.

CASE IN POINT

Someone I know gave themselves one rule: every work task that took more than fifteen minutes, they'd try doing it with AI first. No course, no certificate. Within a month they'd cut their reporting time in half and quietly become the person on their team people asked "how do you use this stuff?" The skill came from use, not study.

CHAPTER SIX

6. Your 90-Day Earning Power Plan

Everything so far is leverage sitting on a shelf. This is where it earns. The plan below ties the first five chapters into one move forward — paced so you're never doing more than a few real things a week.

Pick the track that matches you: a raise where you are, or income on the side. Then work the weeks in order. Don't skip the boring early ones — they're where the leverage gets built.

DAYS 1–30: GET CLEAR AND BUILD THE CASE

- **Week 1.** Run the Skills Audit (Chapter 1). Name your one most valuable, monetizable skill.
- **Week 2.** Do the Compensation Research (Chapter 2). Land on your number with data behind it.
- **Week 3.** Write three impact statements (Chapter 3). Make your value legible to the people who decide.
- **Week 4.** Pick your AI learning path (Chapter 5). Choose the two skills that serve this goal.

DAYS 31–60: MAKE THE MOVE VISIBLE

- **Week 5–6.** Raise track: book the conversation, run the Raise Rehearsal, and ask. Side-income track: have five demand conversations (Chapter 4).
- **Week 7.** Own one recurring problem at work, or make your smallest real offer to one customer.
- **Week 8.** Send a visibility update — to your boss, or to your first potential clients.

DAYS 61–90: LOCK IT IN AND COMPOUND

- **Week 9–10.** Deliver on what you asked for or sold. Over-deliver once, on purpose, and document it.
- **Week 11.** Collect proof — a result, a testimonial, a paid yes — for the next round.
- **Week 12.** Reassess your number and your skill. Set the next 90-day target higher.

90-DAY PLAN BUILDER

"My main goal is [raise to X / earn \$Y on the side / land my first clients]. My most valuable skill is [skill]. I have [X hours] a week. Build me a specific 30/60/90-day plan with 1–3 concrete actions per week that move me toward this. Make week one something I can start today. Flag the one week where most people quit, and tell me how to get through it."

CASE IN POINT

A reader started this with one goal: stop being underpaid. Week 2 gave them a number \$22k above their salary. Week 5 they asked, braced for a fight, and got most of it. The whole thing took six weeks of small, unglamorous steps — a list, some research, one hard conversation. Not a transformation. A sequence.

What to do next.

The through-line of this whole guide is simple: you're probably more valuable than you're being paid for, and the gap is usually visibility and leverage, not skill. AI just makes the work of closing that gap faster — the research, the case, the script, the plan. It doesn't replace your judgment. It hands you back the hours.

So don't try to do all six chapters this week. Do one thing: run the Skills Audit prompt from Chapter 1 today. Fifteen minutes. Find the skill you've been underselling. Everything else in this guide builds on knowing that one answer.

Want a head start?

I pulled the 22 prompts I use most — for pay, positioning, and testing ideas — into one free AI Starter Kit. Copy, paste, go. And if a chapter here hit a nerve, just reply and tell me which one.

Get the free AI Starter Kit

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